

Earphones

Regular earphones bundled with portable digital audio players may or may not complement the player itself. For instance, the earphones provided with the Samsung YP-T5 and the Creatives were extremely good, and reproduced sound with little or no distortion at all, at high volume levels. On the other hand, the earphones bundled with both the Umax Vega and Draco are below par, and do not do justice to the players. To check if the player actually contributed to the degradation of sound reproduction, we plugged in a Sennheiser MX300 (retailing for around \$9.95) earphone into the Umax Draco. The results were very good. These results proved conclusively that the bundled earphones were to be blamed for the degradation of sound quality.

Since you want to listen to music on the go, you can opt for noise-cancellation

or isolation earphones. These earphones are very expensive, but the end result is pure listening pleasure. Both the techniques work in different manners to achieve the same result of getting optimum sound quality without outside interference.

The technique used in noise cancellation headphones is to determine the kind of ambient noise that is being generated, and then produce an inverse sine wave to counter the ambient noise. Consequently, the process cancels the ambient noise and gives a better reproduction.

On the other hand, isolation earphones act in a physical manner, and plug right into your ear canal. An isolation chamber is created, and this way the sound emitted falls directly on your eardrums. No ambient sound is allowed to enter the ear canal. This is called the Acoustic Seal.

Isolation earphones are available from Shure Technologies and Etymotic Research, and are in the price range of \$99 and upwards (and upwards literally means that the sky is the limit!). Noise cancellation earphones are available from companies such as Maxell, JVC, Sennheiser, Bose, etc. Bose has the Bose QuietComfort 2 Acoustic Noise Cancellation Headphones available in India, which retail at Rs 21,900 plus applicable taxes.

High-quality earphones (but not isolation or noise cancellation) are available from Bose, Philips, Technics, Sennheiser, JVC, Panasonic and a range of other brands.

The earphones mentioned above are freely available in the grey market, although you will need someone with some 'pehchaan' to help you get the real thing!

tag the song "Jis Desh Mein Ganga Behti Hai," from the movie by the same name, you wouldn't be able to use the full name. To resolve this, ID3 V2 was devised, and now has become the de-facto standard for tagging in most audio players.

Once this tagging is done, you can use any of your favourite players such as Windows Media Player or iTunes to sync the songs with your MP3 player. And if you don't want to do that, you can simply drag and drop any song that you want into the player (if it shows up as a removable drive in Windows Explorer.)

You have completed all the steps to experience digital music on the go!

Audio Formats And DRM

All the players we received for testing supported the MP3 and WMA formats. While this is good, we did test some players that tread new paths. The Samsung Yepp Sports supports the Ogg Vorbis format, while iPods such as the iPod Mini traditionally support AAC. So is it more feasible to purchase a player that supports newer audio formats? Definitely; because the MP3 format has been done to death, and because there is hardly any development being done on this format. Formats such as WMA, AAC and OGG can give better quality audio files at almost half the size. If you want a high quality MP3 song, the file size increases dramatically. The other formats are therefore fast gaining acceptance.

AAC is the biggest, and thus far, the best format on the audio ripping scene today. This is primarily because you can tweak it to your heart's content, and you will have better sounding files with smaller filesizes. On the other hand, OGG is an open-source format, and there are therefore no royalty issues associated with it. Plus, it gives better quality audio files, almost as good as AAC.



DMS MP301

And with this acceptance of alternative formats comes DRM (Digital Rights Management). AAC and WMA content can be uniquely protected using algorithms that will only let you play the content on some limited devices, including computers and portable players. DRM was devised to take care of illegal copying and sharing of content over the Internet. It has been there with all the new formats, and prevents illegal sharing of music. So a word of warning: if you like alternative formats such as AAC or Ogg, check if the songs that you download are protected by DRM or not, since that will ultimately let you (or not) play the song on your portable player. Songs you rip from CDs do not have DRM, unless you explicitly choose for it to be that way.

Portable Audio Players

Portable Audio Players can generally be classified as the Walkman, Discman and the digital audio player. Digital audio players can be further divided into solid-state and hard drive-based players. Each with its own set of advantages and drawbacks.

If you have a huge music collection, and want to transfer the entire collection to your portable player in one go, a hard drive-based portable player is the way to go. However, if you regularly need fresh music to listen to, and also do not want to invest money in a hard drive-based solution, a flash memory-based solution will work just fine.

FLASH-BASED PORTABLE AUDIO PLAYERS

All the players we received had two things in common. The first was that they could play MP3 songs (except for the Sony Network Walkman) and also act as portable data storage medium. Let's get our hands dirty then with these gizmos and see how they fared against each other.



Sony Network Walkman